



GST 112: NIGERIAN PEOPLES AND CULTURE

The Nigerian State

Nigeria is an area in West Africa bordering the Gulf of Guinea, between Benin and Cameroon. Thus, it shares borders with Benin, Cameroon, Chad and Niger. It has a total land area of 934,768 square kilometres. 13,000 square kilometres of this area is however, covered by water. The geographical area now known as Nigeria evolved from different independent states, kingdoms and empires, including the Borno Empire, the Hausa States, the Sokoto Caliphate in the North; Oyo Empire, Igbo Segmentary societies, Ijaw, Ibio and Benin kingdoms in the South; Tiv, Idoma, Nupe and Igala Kingdoms in the Benue Valley. The country's population which was 45.14 million at independence, increased to over 223 million in 2023. This population is made up of about 300 ethnic groups who speak over 500 languages. Over 20 of these groups are feared to have gone into extinction. This circumstance has led to a national policy on education, which provides for instruction in mother tongues in Nigerian schools. However, the dominant groups include the Hausa-Fulani (29%), Yoruba (21%), Igbo (18%), Ijaw (10%), Kanuri (4%), Ibibio (3.5%), Tiv (2.5%) and others constituting the remaining 12%.

Early Civilisations/Settlements

Archaeological records revealed that as early as 9,000 BC or even earlier, people were already living in the area now called Nigeria. There are also records of early civilisations in the Nigerian area. These include:

1. The Nok Civilisation. Nok is a community in the present day Kaduna State. It produced the best early known civilisation in the Nigerian area, especially in agriculture and iron works. It lasted for 7 centuries (500 BCE-200 BCE). Nok civilisation covers many areas in central Nigeria, including Jos Plateau and Abuja.
2. Igbo-Ukwu Civilisation is another centre of early civilisation in Nigeria. It covers an area in the present Anambra State. It dates back to the 9th century AD and proved existence of early civilisation in government, religion, agriculture, hunting and trade.
3. Ife Civilisation dates back to around 1200 to 1400 C.E. Ife or Ile-Ife is located in the present day Osun State. It is believed to be among the early centres of civilisation, especially in agriculture, trade and iron working.

Notable areas of human settlements were Iwo-Eleru and Okigwe area in southern Nigeria; Taruga an area around the present Federal Capital Territory; and the Jos-Plateau area. These peoples were identified with economic activities such as agriculture, iron technology, pottery, and later trade through the Sahara and the coastal regions. Significant aspects of this development were trade in items and humans (slave trade). slave trade involved the capture and forceful transfer of able-bodied Nigerians mainly to the Americas. It is important to note that despite the Slave Trade Act of 1807, which abolished slavery worldwide, it continued



in Nigeria and Africa generally up to the 1880s and beyond. Another vital aspect of this development was forceful take-over and control of Nigeria area by Britain, otherwise known as colonialism.

Colonialism

The era of industrial revolution in Europe created the need for agricultural commodities, especially palm oil, palm kernel, cocoa and cotton. By the close of the 19th century, trade in the Nigerian area had become highly competitive, especially among European firms. However, in order to avert trade conflicts, Sir Taubman George Goldie amalgamated the competing firms into the National African Company, which later became the Royal Niger Company (RNC) in 1886. Meanwhile, between 1851 and 1961, Lagos had been bombarded and annexed by the British. This control was extended to Yorubaland between 1862 and 1893. The Igbo, Ijaw and other neighbouring ethnic groups became part of the British colonial empire in 1885. However, most of the areas in the Sokoto Caliphate were not conquered until after formal colonial administration in January 1901. Yet, others surrendered. With the conquest of Kano and the surrender of Katsina in 1903, major areas of the north were brought under the British colonial rule except Borno, which was not subdued until the period around 1914.

It is important to state here that many Nigerian areas did not willingly accept British occupation and control. For example, Jaja of Opobo, Nana of Itshekiri, Ovonranwen of Benin, Caliph Muhammadu Attahiru I of Sokoto and others vehemently opposed British control of their areas. Their forces however, could not withstand those of the colonialists as a result of possession of superior military weapons. Consequently, most of such native rulers were deposed and replaced, while others fled. A striking instance of resistance against colonialism was that of Attahiru and many of his followers who organised swift resistance against impeding British colonisation. However, they fell to the superior firepower of the colonialists, suffered heavy casualties and fled Sokoto. In 1903, Attahiru and many of his followers were killed in one of the resistance movements at a place called Mbormi (about 76 kilometres from the present day Gombe). Even after colonisation, some forms of resistance still persisted across Nigeria. These included refusal to pay taxes, avoiding colonial administrators, migrations, and revolts.

With a formal occupation of a substantial part of the Nigerian area, Dame Flora Shaw suggested the name Niger Area in 1900. Shaw was a British journalist and a writer and was later known as Lady Lugard. The name 'Niger Area' was later adopted and modified as 'Nigeria'. For the purpose of administrative convenience, Lagos colony was merged with the Protectorate of Southern Nigeria in 1906. This amalgamation is known as the first ever amalgamation of the British in Nigeria. British government amalgamated Lagos colony and protectorate with the protectorate of Southern Nigeria to form the new colony and protectorate of Southern Nigeria.

On 1st January 1914, the protectorates of Northern and Southern Nigeria were amalgamated. Despite the amalgamation of 1914, Nigeria still operated as a federation of two groups of provinces between 1914 and 1939. Later on April 1, 1939, the British government split the former Southern provinces into Eastern and Western provinces. This tripartite division of Nigeria remained well into the independence period, until 1963 when the Mid-Western region was created, and the Northern Region was split for the first time in 1967



This fusion of hitherto diverse and in some cases, hostile ethnic groups under a single political leader, Sir Frederick Lugard was significant. As the Governor of the new Nigeria, Lugard began the process of integrating all regions by establishing central institutions such as the Central Secretariat in Lagos, the Legislative Council and integration of services of the military, judiciary, treasury, post and telegraphs. However, this integration process was later undermined by rising regional and ethnic consciousness.

Formation of socio-political and Nationalist groups

It is obvious that the British colonial rule alienated Nigerians at different levels. Nigerians became foreigners in their own country. For instance, it became difficult for them to effectively participate in both the economic and governmental processes of their own country. The immediate result of such situation was the birth of Nigerian nationalism. Like in other parts of Africa, some brave Nigerians stood up and decided to champion the cause for reforms in the system. The Nigerian nationalism was welcome both in the country and abroad. Three major trends characterized the strength of nationalistic spirit:

- The people protested against the colonial system in their desire to alter the existing colonial system so that they could benefit from it
- The activities of black diasporas in the New World- the Americas such as Marcus J. Garvey and Wilmot Blyden who were exponents of the dignity of the African person
- The presence of an articulate class of Nigerian elites who through their acquisition of western education were in the vanguard of those agitating for change in the status quo
- *The West African Pilot* and *The Negro World* These were the most prominent newspapers that contributed seriously to the emergence of Nigerian nationalism. Besides, other factors also contributed to the Nigerian nationalism: the development of political parties, and the election of the labour party in Britain with its anti-colonialism agenda. Nigeria became independent on October 1st 1960.
- The Nigerian Youth Movement (NYM). This movement is best known as the “first true nationalist organization” that emerged in Nigeria in 1936. It was headed by Samuel Akinsanya, H. O Davies, Ernest Ikoli and Dr. J.C Vaughan. Dr. Nnamdi Azikiwe and Chief Obafemi Awolowo later joined the movement in 1937.

At this stage of Nigerian history, the earlier resistance to foreign occupation and control took another dimension –demand for self government and formation of social and political associations. Worthy of mention at this period were the National Council of Nigeria and the Cameroons (NCNC) founded by Herbert Macaulay and Nnamdi Azikiwe in 1944; the Action Group (AG), which was officially launched in 1951 by Obafemi Awolowo; the Northern Peoples’ Congress formed in 1949 with Ahmadu Bello, Abubakar Tafawa Balewa and Aminu Kano as its leaders. Unfortunately, these political parties were founded along regional and ethnic lines, and thus not nationalistic in nature. For instance, the NPC developed from a Hausa/Fulani cultural organisation called *Jamiyyar Mutanen Arewa*; developed out of a Yoruba socio-cultural group, *Egbe Omo Oduduwa*, founded London in 1945 by Obafemi Awolowo; the NCNC drew its major support from the Igbo ethnic group. This development laid a foundation for regional and ethnic nationalism and politics in the future Nigeria. Between 1957 and 1959, independence was granted to Regional governments in the East, West and North. In 1960, Nigeria was granted her independence from British colonial rule.



Challenges at independence

Nigeria became independent on October 1 1960 with Abubakar Tafawa Balewa as its first Prime Minister while Nnamdi Azikiwe became the President. On October 1 1963, Nigeria became a Republic. Despite the fact that Azikiwe was the President, Balewa was seen as more powerful. The newly independent Nigeria was sadly overwhelmed with numerous unresolved challenges, which shook her to its foundation. These challenges were apparently rooted in the regional and ethnic interest as discussed above. A major challenge at this period was the census controversies among the Regions in 1962 and 1963. It was so controversial because of allegations of manipulation of figures by different regions. This was done in consideration of dominance and control of government at the centre.

The 1964-1965 election crisis was another challenge. The parliamentary elections were held between December 1963 and March 1964. However, it was marred by violence, intimidation and alleged manipulation of figures to favour the NPC. The NPC Abubakar Tafawa Balewa was re-elected Prime Minister. The crises that ensued were so challenging to Nigeria as the existing mistrust and hostility among various regions and ethnic groups intensified. A major effect of this was the January, 1966 military coup led by Chukwuemeka Kaduna Nzeogu and Emmanuel Ifeajuna. This claimed the lives of many prominent politicians, army officers and their wives in the North and West. Some of them were the Prime Minister (Tafawa Balewa) Premiers of the North and West (Ahmadu Bello and Samuel Akintola) and the Finance Minister (Okotie Eboh). The whole event was seen in some quarters as an Igbo conspiracy, especially when Aguiyi Ironsi was appointed to head the military government and there were cases of promotion of several Igbo military officers from the rank of Major to Lieutenant Colonel. On July 28 1966, General Murtala Muhammed led a group of military officers dominated by the North to stage a counter coup or what was referred to as 'July Rematch'. Some of the officers included T.Y. Danjuma, Ibrahim Babangida, Shitu Alao, Muhammadu Buhari, Sani Abacha, B. S. Dimka, Mamman Vatsa and Muhammed G. Nasko. Head of the military government in the January coup, Ironsi was killed in the process. In addition, many Igbo people living in northern Nigeria were killed. Yakubu Gowon was appointed to head the government after the counter coup.

In addition to the above crises threatening the unity of Nigeria, Isaac J. A. Boro led a movement that declared the Niger Delta Republic in February, 1966. Their major grievance with the Nigerian government was that they did not enjoy adequate share of the proceeds of the oil wealth that was derived from their land. Using an Ijaw dominated armed militia formation, the Niger Delta Volunteer Force, Boro fought the Federal forces for more than a week before being defeated and jailed for treason. However, a twist of event saw the release of Boro, enlistment into the Nigerian army and fighting on the side of the Nigerian army during the Civil War in 1967.

Meanwhile, citing cases of ethno-religious violence, political instability and killing of Igbo people in Northern Nigeria, Chukwuemeka Odumegwu Ojukwu, the Military Governor of the Eastern Region asked all Igbo people to return home. He then declared the Republic of Biafra in May 1967. The Federal Government declared war on the state of Biafra immediately. This war did not end until the flight of Ojukwu to the neighbouring Ivory Coast and the surrender of Biafran forces on 15th January, 1970. This was



after a heavy military casualty of about 100 thousand, starvation-related death of about 2 million, strained health care, loss of property and displacement.

The implication of the foregoing discussion is that the political and social systems of Nigeria were largely founded on regional, ethnic and religious, rather than national interest. The political fusion of diverse ethnic groups, numbering between 250 to 300 in a single state was therefore, problematic. This manifested in the ethnic and religious colouration given to almost everything, including census, politics and administration, resource allocation, as well as appointments. Despite efforts made by the Federal Government to surmount these challenges, they still continue to manifest in the current Nigerian polity. This has overtime created instability, insurgency and insecurity in different parts of Nigeria. In the South East for example, the agitation for Biafra was rekindled in 1999 through a separatist group, Movement for the Actualisation of the Sovereign State of Biafra (MASSOB). This group under the leadership of Ralph Uwazuruike had a flag, security network, currency and international passport other than that of the Federal Republic of Nigeria. In 2012, there was yet another transition from MASSOB to Independent People of Biafra IPOB under the leadership of Mazi Nnamdi Kanu. It is believed that IPOB is committed to the cause of the defunct Republic of Biafra. A similar separatist group also existed in the South West with the intention of creating the Oduduwa Republic. In the North East, similar agitations existed since 2009 through activities of the *Jamā'at Ahl as-Sunnah lid-Da'wah wa'l-Jihād* (The Group of the People of Sunnah for Preaching and Struggle) and recently as *Wilāyat Gharb Ifrīqīyyah* (The Islamic State's West Africa Province). Their common name is Boko Haram, meaning "Western education is forbidden." Their major aim is to carve out an Islamic State out of Nigeria. However, apart from a separate flag, their major threat to the Nigerian state lies in violent attacks on government institutions and individuals. Their activities are often linked to ethno-religious ideology.

In view of the above grievances against the Nigerian state, there is the need to redefine the terms of the Federation, to identify the difference between national and ethnic/regional interests and to emphasize more on issues of unity rather than those of division. Worthy of mention in this context are reinvigoration of the following state policies:

- a. The National Youth Service Corps scheme established in 1974 to ensure national unity, common national identity and integration
- b. Federal Character system to ensure equitable and balanced appointment into public offices as enshrined in Section 14 of the 1999 Constitution of Nigeria
- c. States and local government creation to bring government closer and to address the needs of minority ethnic groups
- d. Resource control to ensure equitable distribution of commonwealth in such a way that no region is too poor and no region is too rich

These, to a large extent have ensured a sense of belonging, unity, harmony, tolerance and common national interests among the diverse ethnic groups, and thus, ensured proper planning and overall development of the country.



ETHNIC GROUPS IN NIGERIA

Evolution of the Nigerian state as discussed above involved fusion of diverse independent empires and kingdoms such as the Borno Empire, the Sokoto Caliphate, the Benin Kingdom, Oyo Empire and the Igbo segmentary societies, just to mention a few. There are about 300 ethnic groups speaking over 500 languages across the country. The Northern Nigeria, dominated by the Hausa/Fulani comprises other ethnic groups such as the Kanuri, Tiv, Nupe, Jukun, Igala, Ngas, Kutep, Karekare, Kakanda, Tarok, Chamba, Kilba, Tangale, Buh, Gbagi, Zuru and Mumuye. They are further grouped into north east, north-west and north central. The Southern Nigeria on the other hand, is dominated by the Yoruba and the Igbo ethnic groups. Other ethnic groups in this region include the Bini, Ishekiri, Ijaw, Ndoki, Ibibio, Ikwere, Ogoni and Urhobo. They are also grouped into south-east, south-south, and south-west. While the south-east and the south-west are dominated by the Igbo and the Yoruba respectively, the south-south comprises numerous minority ethnic groups.

While the list of ethnic groups in these regions is a long one, Nigeria has three official major ethnic groups, namely the Hausa/Fulani, Yoruba and the Igbo. It is important to state that the complexity in Nigeria's ethnic configuration could be seen when one looks at the state formation process of these groups. For instance, it was a union of various groups such as the Egba, Ijebu, Ilaje and a host of others that formed what we now know as the Yoruba. In the same vein, it was a union of various Hausa states such as Zazzau, Rano, Gobir and a host of others that formed the Hausa/Fulani ethnic group. It is believed that the Igbo has the least internal diversity. However, the Onitsha dialect has been acclaimed to be a central one. The cosmopolitan nature of Onitsha was believed to have started in the mid 19th century. Nevertheless, the majority ethnic groups constitute the following percentage of Nigeria's population; Hausa (29%), Yoruba (21%) and Igbo (18%).

We shall now discuss selected ethnic groups from the above list; Hausa/Fulani, the Yoruba, Igbo and few from the minority groups. Accordingly, our discussion shall highlight their traditions of origin, economic and political organisation. It is important to state that the traditions of origin of these groups are largely shrouded in oral tradition, ethnic consciousness and myths or legends. To this end, certain characteristics are common to them; stories of creation, migration from important places and political ambition of their leaders.

THE HAUSA

Hausa is a language that is widely spoken in Africa, next to Swahili. It also refers to the people. It is the largest ethnic group in northern Nigeria, comprising the present 19 northern states and the Federal Capital Territory. This status was established after the 1804 Usman Dan Fodio jihad. The jihad led to conquest and assimilation of erstwhile independent Hausa states of Rano, Zamfara, Katsina, Zazzau, Gobir and Kebbi. Before the jihad, these states were noted for unhealthy rivalry, internal conflicts individualism and struggle for supremacy and control of the Trans-Saharan Trade. In addition, there were cases of corruption, economic exploitation, slavery and pagan practices, especially talisman and divination. These and a serious leadership gap provided Usman Dan Fodio an opportunity to launch his jihad, with the following objectives;

- a. Establishment of a theocratic state built upon a purer form of Islam



- b. Addressing the oppression of the masses or *talakawa*
- c. Emphasis on knowledge, scholarship or learning
- d. Migration or *hijra* in situations of helplessness
- e. Collective war against oppressors

Execution of the jihad in line with the above objectives produced the following effects;

- a. Adoption of Hausa as lingua franca and language of administration
- b. Emergence of Hausa-Fulani solidarity and collectivism
- c. Spread of Islam up to the Benue Valley and Yorubaland
- d. Emergence of Fulani aristocracy in place of Hausa aristocracy

Traditions of Origin of the Hausa

The dominant and most acceptable oral tradition that attempts to explain the origin of the Hausa is the Bayajida legend. Bayajida also known as Abu Yazid in some traditions was believed to be a Prince who fled from Baghdad in the Middle East to Kanem Borno. He later married Magira, a daughter of the King (*Mai*), a marriage that produced a child. Bayajida later abandoned his family and fled to Daura where he killed a sacred snake that prevented the people from accessing water from a well except on Fridays. The Queen of Daura was highly impressed and offered to marry the hero. The marriage produced a son, Bawo and five other children who, along with the first child from Magira, formed the seven states of Biram, Daura, Katsina, Kano, Rano, Zazzau and Gobir otherwise known as the *Hausa Bokwai*. Other seven states that later emerged were Kebbi, Zamfara, Nupe, Gwari, Yauri, Ilorin and Kwararafa, and are referred to as *Banza Bokwai*.

Economy

The economy of the Hausa state was built on;

- a. Agriculture –crops such as millet, maize, guinea corn and beans were produced abundantly
- b. Industry –leather works, weaving and dyeing of cloths
- c. Trade, especially long distance trade

Political Organisation

The political institution in the Hausa state was operated on the basis of Islam and the Sharia. Apart from influence of the jihadists, the area had been exposed to Islamic religion since the 14th and 15th centuries. At the apex of the political system was the *Sarkin kasa*. He was the chief executive who performed political and religious functions. He was also head of the Judiciary. As the Sharia system gradually gained prominence, other offices were established. For example, office of the judicial head, *Qadi* or *alkali* and other royal officials who assisted in the royal functions; the *Galadima* (senior councillor), *Madawaki* (palace administrator), *Magaji* (overseer) and *Dogari* (guard). The government was funded through *zakat* (alms), *jangali* (cattle tax) and tributes.



THE FULANI

The Fulani, also known as Fellata, Fula or Fulbe are often discussed side by side with the Hausa, especially since the jihadist movement. Their origin is not clear and they do not have a particular territory. However, they are widely believed to have originated from the Upper Senegal and Futajalon highlands and later moved to northern Nigeria. Yet, their lineage is often traced to an Arab named Uqba bin Nafi. There are two categories of Fulani;

- a. The nomadic Fulani, also known as *Fulanin daji* or *Fulanin bororo*. They move from one place to another in search of pasture or grazing land for their livestock. Ownership of cows is part of their culture and a definition of their wealth.
- b. The sedentary Fulani, also known as *Fulanin gida*. They settle in towns and villages and engage in economic activities such as farming, teaching and trading.

Using their bravery in administration, military and agriculture, and in alliance with their kinsman, Usman Dan Fodio, they were able to alter to their favour the political equation in Hausaland, colonial and post-colonial Nigeria and West Africa at large. They have produced, among other positions, a good number of heads of government in Nigeria, Senegal, Gambia and Guinea Bissau. In Nigeria, as a result of a merger, most discussions on the Fulani are now done side by side with those of the Hausa.

THE YORUBA

The Yoruba ethnic group is believed to have been in existence since the period between 2000 to 1000 BC. They have the following areas as their traditional homeland; Ile-Ife, Oyo and Iwo-Eleru (near Akure and Owo). Presently, they are found in the following states; Lagos, Oyo, Ogun, Ondo, Ekiti, Osun, and parts of Kogi and Kwara. They are also found in eastern Benin (formerly Dahomey), northern Ghana, Togo and Brazil.

Traditions of Origin

There are two versions on the origin of the Yoruba; Ife and Oyo versions.

1. According to the **Ife version**, *Olodumare* or *Olorun* (the Most High God) sent sixteen Oye (immortals) from heaven to come and create the earth and human beings out of water. The sixteen-member delegation, led by Obatala included Oduduwa, Obawinrin and Obamerin. On their way, Obatala was intoxicated after drinking palm wine. Oduduwa then seized the symbols of authority – five pieces of iron, a cockerel and a lump of earth tied to a white piece of cloth and led them to the world. They descended at Oke Oramfe in Ile-Ife where Oduduwa set down the five pieces of iron, placed the lump of earth on them and made the cockerel to spread them. The earth was thus, formed in this process including other Yoruba towns and villages and Oduduwa became the ruler. Ile-Ife is therefore, believed to be the centre from which the world was created. However, another version



suggested that Oduduwa was an aggressor who used force to take over power from Obatala who had established himself earlier. This is seen as the basis for unending rivalries between their parties, especially during festivals.

2. The second version on the origin of the Yoruba is the **Oyo Tradition or Rev. Samuel Johnson version**. According to this version, the Yoruba migrated from Mecca, passed through Yemen and Egypt to their present location. The migration was inspired by outbreak of a civil war following the rise of Islam in Mecca. Prominent among these migrants were Oduduwa, Gogobiri and Kukawa, children of a Meccan King called Lamurudu. While Oduduwa and his children settled at Ile-Ife, Gogobiri and Kukawa formed two Hausa tribes. A similar account was recorded by Muhammed Bello, the son Uthman dan Fodio

Economy:

The economy of the Yoruba was built primarily on agriculture. Other important aspects of the economy were trading, blacksmithing, carving and sculpturing. Some of these formed the foundation and growth of the Yoruba arts and culture.

Political Organisation:

The Yoruba society was cosmopolitan right from the earliest period. Thus, they had early organised and effective political system that clustered around Ile-Ife. Ile-Ife developed a strong economic system, centralized political system, as well as complex cultural and spiritual practices that later became a model for other Yoruba communities. While Ile-Ife continued to be the spiritual headquarters of Yorubaland, Oyo soon developed a more complex political and military system. The renowned kingdom of Oyo was founded by Oramiyan a son of Oduduwa in the 15th century. The kingdom's influence later dominated other Yoruba towns and up to Dahomey. This dominance was as a result of its military and economic strength as well as political stability.

At the head of the political system was the Alaafin who was regarded as "the lord of many lands and companion of the gods." The Oyomesi (council of seven), headed by the Bashorun (prime minister), was there to regulate or checkmate the power of the Alaafin. The council had the power to hire or fire an Alaafin according to the tradition. When an Alaafin is removed, he is expected to commit suicide. There was also another important component of the political system, the Ogboni cult. Made up of prominent members of the society, the Oyomesi and representatives of the Alaafin, the Ogboni cult served as a counter force and a mediator in any conflict between the Alaafin and the Oyomesi. The Army or Are-Ona-Kankanfo was another important unit of the traditional political system of the Yoruba including 70 war chiefs. It was the military arm of the government charged with the responsibility of maintaining stability, security and expansion. A breakdown of these checks and balances was witnessed in the 18th century when Bashorun Gaha assumed so much power. Gaha was known to have raised five Alaafin and destroyed four of them. This breakdown was also at the root of the Yoruba internecine war that lasted for almost a century.



THE IGBO

The traditional homeland of the Igbo are south eastern Nigerian states of Imo, Anambra, Enugu, Ebonyi, Abia and parts of Delta and Rivers.

Origins of the Igbo

Like in other groups, the origin of the Igbo people is controversial. There are so many versions and it is very difficult to say which is the most acceptable.

The Middle East Version

Some believe that the Igbo peoples migrated to their present location from either the North or the Middle-east.

The Igboland Centred Version

Others believe that the Igbo people had been in their present abode from the beginning. Therefore, Igboland is the original homeland.

The Nri Version

This version says the Igbo descended from the sky. According to Nri version, the ancestor of the Igbo, Eri, descended from the sky and sailed down the River Anambra. When he arrived at Aguleri, he met some autochthonous group of people who had no living memory of their own and settled with them. As their population increased, some groups migrated to other parts of Igboland to establish their own settlements.

The Awka or Orlu Version

This version claims that the Igbo societies such as Nri, Awka and Orlu have been in existence since around 2,500 BC. It was from these places that they later spread to other areas. Thus, this tradition considered Awka or Orlu towns as the center of origin of the Igbo from where they dispersed to other areas.

The Idah Version

Some groups such as the Umunri claim to have migrated to their present location from Idah.

The Benin Version

The Onitsha and the Igbo on the other side of the River Niger [Delta Igbo], claim Benin origin.

The Israeli Version

One of the most popular versions of the migratory stories of origin of the Igbo people is the one that points to Israel. This assumption is based on the so-called similarities between the cultures of the Igbo and the ancient Hebrew. Some Igbo scholars consider themselves as off-shoots of the lost tribes of the Hebrews who migrated southward. You should remember that the Igbo society has always been known as acephalous. Moreover, there were very limited professional historians as at that period. There were no equivalents of Oba, and Alaafin or of palaces over most parts of Igboland. This is why it is very difficult to reconcile all these various versions.

The Socio-Political Organization of the Igbo

Unlike other ethnic groups such as the Yoruba and the Bini, the Igbo people did not build any strong centralized states. This is mainly because Igbo society had always been fragmentary or acephalous. In traditional Igbo for instance, the village was the centre of government.

This has been described as direct democracy. The village-centered administration implied that every linkage for instance, including all male adults in the village, participated in its political process.

The Amala Oha

You should always remember that the socio-political organization of the traditional Igbo was fundamentally based either on the age grades or age and titled societies. Amala Oha was therefore a form of general assembly in traditional Igbo society. All the male adult members usually met in this assembly to perform legislative functions. In ancient times, the Amala Oha's meetings were held in the open village square. All the decisions taken during those meetings were absolute and final. As a democratic society, the life of every individual was



highly respected. More so, the recognition of an individual in the society was based on individual capability and age rather than family background. The elders formed the core of village administration. They were highly respected accordingly. Hardworking and wealthy individuals were respected and given important responsibilities in the society as well. The youth, middle age or able-bodied men and elders constituted age-sets or age groups. You should remember that each age-set had its own special rights, duties, obligations and responsibilities in matters affecting the village.

The Igbo traditional political system was segmentary or autonomous characterized by a hierarchy of power from the family to the age group and to special title holders. This is in spite of emergence of a paramount ruler (*Obi*) for centralized communities such as Onitsha. The village group assembly, made up of lineages, was the basic unit of political organization. Each lineage was headed by *Okpara* (the oldest son) a representative of the ancestors. His symbol of authority and justice was the *Ofo*. Powers were also held among the following: *Ozo*, *Ichie*, *Mazi*, *Ozioko*, *Nze*, *Diokpa*, *Isi* and *Ezeji*. Similarly, the priests, elders, diviners, medicine men, the *Okpara*, members of secret society and age grades also possessed important powers within the Igbo political set up. It is important to note the all-inclusive or democratic nature of Igbo political system. This has often led to claims in some quarters that the Igbo possessed one of the most democratic institutions in the pre-colonial history of Nigeria.

Economy

The basic components of the traditional economic system of the Igbo were agriculture, trade and industry. In agriculture, cultivation of root crops such as yam was well known. Items such as palm oil and slaves dominated trade. On the other hand, industrial activities included blacksmithing especially in Awka area. The entrepreneurial culture of the Igbo is however, dominated by trade and industry.

SOME MINORITY ETHNIC GROUPS

As earlier mentioned, in addition to the official three major languages discussed above, there are numerous minority groups. Here, we shall discuss selected few such as the Kanuri, Benin, Nupe, Itsekiri. Our discussion here shall however, highlight their traditions of origin and political organization.

THE BENIN

The Benin, also known as Bini or Edo are found in southern Nigeria. It is believed that the Bini, more than any other ethnic group, have played major roles in the history of Nigeria. Formed around the 11th century, the Benin Empire was one of the first areas to have contact with the Europeans. For instance, a Portuguese, Ruy de Sequeira, arrived during Oba Ewuare's reign in 1472 while Alfonso de Aviero arrived during Ozolua's reign in 1484. It was also the first empire on the West African coast to exchange ambassadors with the Europeans between 1481 and 1504. The Benin are well known for their arts within and outside Nigeria.

There are three versions of the origin of the Benin kingdom.

1. The first version claims that the Benin Kingdom was founded by the youngest child of *Osanubua* (the high God). This child came with his elder brothers who subsequently founded Ife and Yoruba Kingdoms.



2. The Second version states that the elders of Benin requested the King of Ife (*Oduduwa*) to send his son to serve as king of Benin. *Oduduwa* thus sent *Oranmiyan* whose stay in Benin was short lived. During his short stay, he impregnated the daughter of the *Onogie* of Edo. This woman later delivered a son who was installed as the first *Oba* of Benin. This *Oba* was later known as *Eweka*. He and the people of Benin lived at *Usama*.
3. The third version states that the Bini migrated from Egypt and in the course of their journey southward, they settled at Ile-Ife and finally moved to their present location.

The Socio-Political Organization of the Bini

As stated above, the Bini kingdom was the first in the West Coast of Africa to exchange ambassadors with a major European power. This was between 1481 and 1504. At that time, the Bini kingdom was already socio-politically well organized. Bini kingdom had a unique political system, which centered on the Oba. He was the head of the kingdom and succession to the throne was by primogeniture, that is, the first surviving son succeeded his father. The Oba was not only the civil head of state; he was also the religious head as well. He was in fact regarded as a divine person who had a divine spirit passed on to him from his forebears.

The Bini society was classified into two distinct classes: the nobility and the commoner. The nobility was organized into three groups of title holders:

- The Uzama
- The Egbaevbo n' Ogbe [palace chiefs] and
- The Egbaevbo n' ore [town chiefs]

The ordinary people too, most especially those within the city, were organized into a number of guilds. The guilds were professional groups of the common people. There were a number of them such as those of the carvers, brass-workers, blacksmiths, doctors, butchers, etc. These guilds, most especially those that lived in defined quarters in the kingdom, had a system of administration which was the same as that of the villages. Thus, the political organization of the Benin was segmentary, deriving authority from the nuclear family, joint family and the extended family. Each of these was headed by an elder who represented them at the village level. There were also title holders who administered law and justice in entire kingdom.

THE ITSEKIRI

There are three versions on the origin of Itsekiri.

1. The people of Itsekiri claimed to have descended from *Umale-Okun* (the sea god)
2. In another version, they claimed to have descended from *Ode*, a Yoruba town in Ijebu.
3. They also claimed a relationship with *Iginuwa*, a son of one of the chiefs of the Yoruba. It was said that *Iginuwa* was sent to the Itsekiri land in company of chiefs and their servants who, together with the



Itsekiri established the present land. On his arrival, *Iginuwa* met with some Ijaw who took him along with his followers and consolidated his power as a leader of the new land.

The political system of the Itsekiri is headed by the Olu who is also the spiritual leader. Another important unit of the political system is the *Ojoye*, a Council of seven nobles and title holders. This is similar to the *Oyomesi* in Yorubaland.

THE KANURI

The Kanuri are found in Borno and Yobe States. There are two versions of the tradition of origin of the Kanuri;

1. The “**So**” **Version** claims that there were original settlers in Kanem Borno. Over time, they developed a sophisticated socio-political culture through agriculture and iron technology.
2. The second version is the **Saif bin Dhi Yazan**. According to this version, the foundation of Kanem Borno was laid between the 9th and the 10th centuries CE to an Arab, Saif bin Dhi Yazan.

The central political system was headed by the *Mai* or king. Other important office holders were the Maigira (Mai’s mother), Mogaran (Mai’s sister) as administrative assistant, the Khadi (Chief Judge and legal advisor to the Mai), the Nokena (Council of the twelve) as state council and advisory body, the army and titled nobility. The slaves and eunuchs also had the following important offices; Mushemu, Yuroma and Kachalla. There were other offices at the provinces such as the Galadima and Yerima (provincial governors), Kaigama (army chief) and Mustrema (representative of the Queen’s mother)

THE NUPE

The Nupe are found in the central Nigerian area along the Niger Benue valley. There are three traditions of origin of the Nupe;

the first version claims that they originated from their present location in parts of Kogi Kwara and Niger States. The second version states that they originated from Egypt. The third version however, claims that they originated from Igala. According to the third version, Edegi (the founder) arrived from Idah to found the kingdom in the 16th century. They paid tribute and allegiance to the Attah Igala at Idah until another Idah Prince, Tsoede asserted their independence and became the Etsu (king).

The Etsu is the head of the Kingdom. He is assisted at the central level by members of the nobility; Shaba, Kpotu and Maku. At the provincial or village level, there was the Zitsu and a council of elders.

THE IGALA

The Igala are found in central Nigeria at the confluence of Rivers Benue and Niger. Few of them are also found in parts of Igboland and Edo state. There are three versions of traditions of origin of the Igala: First, the Abutu Eje version, which states that the Igala kingdom evolved through a foreigner known as Abutu Eje. He was believed to be either a Benin or Jukun Prince raised by a leopard and later assumed leadership of the



area. Secondly, another version states attributes the emergence of Igala state to Achadu, an Igbo who later married Ebulejonu, the female Igala King. The third version, relying on contiguous borders and cultural/linguistic similarities, claims that Igala originated from the Yoruba.

The political system was headed by the Attah who was assisted by a council of nine chiefs known as Igalamela as well as other palace officials. Igalamela was headed by the Achadu. There were two levels of government; central and provincial administration.

THE BIROM

The Birom are largely located in Plateau State but are also found in Bauchi and Kaduna States. They speak the Birom language which belongs to the large Niger-Congo family of languages. The Birom ethnic group which currently constitute the largest indigenous group on the Jos Plateau migrated into their present abode from Central Africa as Bantu migrants who took their journey from Ethiopia through Sudan to Chad, and then to Niger before settling down at Gobir close to Sokoto from where they moved before finally settling down at Riyom from where they eventually spread to Xwang, Forom Zawan, Kuru, Gyel, Haipan, Fan and Gashish.

The Birom are predominantly farmers and hunters who celebrate their occupations through series of cultural festivals such as Mandyang (rain festival – usually marked between March – April), Nshor (hunting festival – usually marked between April – May) Nzem Berom (music, dance, arts cultural day mandatory marked every first week of April). The Birom political system prior to the advent of colonialism functioned more as a chieftain under the Gwoms (village heads) and Da Gwoms (village heads) until the establishment of the stool of the paramount ruler for the entire Birom land known as Gbong Gwom Jos in 1935.

THE TIV

The Tiv ethnic group, though predominantly domiciled in Benue State are also found in Nassarawa, Taraba, Plateau and the Federal Capital Territory. The Tiv which form part of the Bantu continuum lived within the Cameroun–Obudu complex between 1475 and 1505 before moving down the hills into the Benue Valley through four waves of migration that lasted between 1475–1900. The reason for migration from Swem around the Cameroon–Obudu Plateau has been attributed to diverse factors such as inter and intra ethnic hostilities, population explosion and the gradual decline of the Kwararafa military efficacy in the Lower Benue Valley. The migrations of the Tiv into the Benue Valley was accompanied with series of warfare against the Jukun, Chamba, Idoma, the Alago, the Hausawa/Katsinawa and the Kamberi.

The Tiv in their interaction with their neighbours had imbibed so much in terms of farming techniques and technology, cultural practice and political system. The Tiv who emerged from Swem as an egalitarian society by the 19th century instituted a political system, Tor Agbande (Drum chief) which they copied from the Jukun. The Tor Agbande held sway at the kindred level where they offered both political and military leadership to their people. With the advent of colonialism, the British in their attempt to implement the indirect rule system created the offices of district heads and subsequently that of the paramount ruler of Tivland, Tor Tiv by 1945. The seat of the Tor Tiv is in Gboko which in contemporary time is regarded as the traditional headquarter of Tivland.

The Tiv are predominantly farmers. A significant portion of the population are also engaged in trading and merchandise. The advent of Christianity in Tivland has significantly altered the people's belief system in favour of the Christian faith. *Nongu u Kristu u i ser u sha Tar* (Universal Reformed Christian



Church) NKST one of the largest indigenous Christian Mission in Nigeria is a proof of the tremendous impact of Christianity.

THE JUKUN

The Jukun who speak six dialects, Wukari, Donga, Kona, Gwana and Pindiga, Jibu and Wase Tofa are located in Taraba, Benue, Nassarawa, Plateau, Adamawa and Gombe States, and some parts of northwestern Cameroon. The Jukun states presided over chunks of Gongola and Benue river basins over a long period of time stretching from the 14th to the 18th century A.D. One of their traditions of origin claims that they are of the same stock with the Kanuri of Borno. It is, thus, stated that they migrated with the Kanuri to Borno where they left them and then continued their movement southwards before settling along the Gongola and Benue River basins. Whereas between the 14th century and the 15th century, Jukun suffered so much in the hands of Kano and Zaria who occasionally raided her territories and exerted much tributes, as from the 16th century up to the 18th century Jukun became a formidable military force that posed serious threat to Borno, Kano, Zaria, the surrounding areas of Jos Plateau and to some parts of the Cross River basin.

A centralised political system of the Jukun is represented by the Aku of Wukari. The Jukun are divided into two major groups, the Jukun Wanu and Jukun Wapa. The Jukun Wanu are fishermen residing along the banks of the river Benue and Niger where they run through Taraba State, Benue State and Nassarawa State. The Jukun Wapa are the homeland Jukun that lives around Wukari. Even though the traditional stool of Aku of Wukari was able to survive after the Fulani conquest of Jukun, the initial cohesiveness of the people were disrupted as shown in the case of the Jukun in Adamawa State who were brought under the rulership of the Fulani emir of Muri. Prior to the advent of colonialism, Jukun were predominantly traditional worshipers. The coming of Christianity has significantly altered the people's belief system, as most Jukun, including their paramount ruler have embraced the Christian faith.

DEFINITION OF CULTURE

Let us start by defining the word **culture** as the universal human capacity to classify, and communicate their experiences symbolically. The word culture is from the Latin word *colere*, with its original meaning "to cultivate". Culture has been defined as "the way of life of a people." As such, it includes codes of manners, dress, language, religion, rituals, norms of behaviors and systems of belief.

A common way to explain culture is to see it as consisting of four elements that are "passed on from generation to generation by learning alone". They are **values, norms, institutions** and **artifacts**.

- Values include ideas about what seems important in life .
- Norms consist of expectations of how people will and should behave in various situations.
- Institutions are the structures of a society within which values and norms are taught and learned.
- Artifacts—things, or aspects of material culture gotten from values and norms of culture.

To a layman, culture may mean eating habits, drumbeats, farming techniques, hair plaiting, tribal mark pattern, folk tales and songs expressed by people in a given environment. Culture transformed man from animal in to a human being. It is a learned behaviour acquired by experience, as opposed to in-born and genetically determined behaviour. Culture includes those ways of thinking, feeling and acting that the



members of one society simply takes for granted, but which might seem very strange to an outsider.

According to Edward B. Tylor (1871), culture is that “complex whole which includes knowledge, beliefs, arts, morals, laws, customs and any other capabilities and habits acquired by man as a member of society”.

Linton (1940), viewed culture as “the sum total of knowledge, attitudes and habitual behaviour patterns, shared and transmitted by the members of a particular society”.

Culture is the dynamic aspect of social life. It is created by the society as the generational guide through which man as a member of homosapiens sees himself regulating his activities, integrating himself with large network of social regulations, and satisfying his needs. Culture distinguishes human groups from others and humans from animals. It is a shared social behaviour learned by members of the society through the process of socialization from birth to the grave.

Types of Culture

1. **Material Culture:** Material cultures are the aspects of culture that can be seen, felt and touched. They consist of manufactured objects such as tools, furniture, automobile, building, irrigation ditches, roads, bridges and in fact any physical substance, which has been changed as used by people. Such manufactured objects are called artefacts. In the game of football for instance, the boots, socks, jersey and the ball itself are the few elements of material culture.
2. **Non-Material Culture:** These are the aspects of culture that make people's behaviour. They consist of the words people use, the ideas, customs, and beliefs they hold, and the habits they follow. For example, in the game of football, the non-material aspects of culture include the rules of the game, player's skills, concepts of strategy, and the traditional behaviour of players and spectators.

Components of Culture

- a. **Symbols:** One among the important things that people of a particular culture share is a common set of symbols. A “symbol” is a representation of something else that can communicate information in shorthand form. Symbols allow people to make sense of their lives and make human existence meaningful. For example, the cross symbolizes Christianity while that of star and moon symbolizes Islam.
- b. **Language:** Language is a symbol system with words representing objects, actions, feelings and other aspects of our experiences. Language can also mean a set of sounds with a particular meaning attached to each sound. For instance, a Yoruba man can be identified by the way he speaks or greet a person. As a symbol, language can take the form of spoken or written words.
- c. **Values:** Values are agreements about what is good or acceptable in a given society. Values are beliefs which underpin a society and provide general principles of behaviour. For instance, embracing peace is based on the agreement that it is bad to kill each other.
- d. **Norms:** Norms are agreements about what is generally expected of members of a particular culture. Norms are specific rules which guide human behaviour in a given situation. In India for



example, the norm is that people will not kill or eat cattle, while in Nigeria, beef is eaten freely when available.

Norms are of two types;

- i. Folkways: Norms performed widely, but not necessary e.g eating with knives and forks.
- ii. Mores: Strong feeling of what is right or wrong whose violations attract sanctions in the society e.g pick-pocketing, arson, rape, etc.

Characteristics of culture

- a. **Culture is learned** through socialization. It is not inherited biologically, but learnt socially by man. It is not an inborn tendency. There is no cultural instinct as such culture is often “Learned ways of behavior”. Unlearned behaviour such as closing the eyes while sleeping, the eye blinking reflex and so on, are purely physiological and not cultural. Shaking hands or “thanks” on the other hand, are cultural. Similarly, wearing clothes, combing the hair, wearing ornaments, drinking from a glass, eating from a plate, etc. are all ways of behaviour learnt by man culturally.
- b. **Culture is shared** among members of the society. It is not something that an individual alone can possess. For example, customs, traditions, beliefs, ideas, values, morals etc. are all shared by people of a group or society. Culture is something adopted, used, believed, practiced or possessed by more than one person. It depends upon group life for its existence.
- c. **Culture is transmissive**. Culture is passed from generation to generation. Culture is capable of being transmitted from one generation to the other. Parents pass on culture traits to their children, and they in turn to their children, and so on. Culture is transmitted not through genes but by means of language. Language is the main vehicle of culture. Language in its different forms like reading, writing, and speaking makes it possible for the present generation to understand the achievements of earlier generations. But language itself is a part of a culture. Once language is acquired, transmission of culture may take place by imitation as well as by instruction.
- d. **Culture varies from one society to another**. Every society has a culture of its own. It differs from society to society. Culture of every society is unique to itself. Cultures are not uniform. Culture elements such as customs, traditions, morals, ideas, values, ideologies etc, are not uniform everywhere. Ways of eating, speaking, greeting, dressing, entertaining, living etc, of different societies differ significantly. Culture varies from time to time also. No culture ever remains constant.
- e. **Culture is dynamic and adaptive**. Though culture is relatively stable it is not altogether static. It is subjected to slow but constant changes over time. Culture is therefore dynamic. Culture is responsive to the changing conditions of the physical world. It is adaptive. It also intervenes in the natural environment and helps man in his process of adjustment. Culture assists us to survive and adapt to the changes.

Other important concepts related to culture

- a. **Ethnocentrism**: This can be defined as that view of things in which one's own group is the centre of anything and all others are scaled and rated with reference to it. In other words, it refers to the view that one's culture is most superior to others. An example is the “civilising mission” of Europeans during colonialism; and the holocaust involving Nazi's determination to exterminate all the Jews in



Europe. This resulted in the killing of over 5 million Jews in the 1940s.

- b. **Xenocentrism:** This refers to the tendency to view one's culture as inferior. An example is the quest for foreign culture among Nigerians –dress, food, language, etc
- c. **Cultural Relativism:** This refers to the recognition that different group have different sets of agreements without the feeling that one set is superior to another. This enhances understanding and tolerance among diverse groups.
- d. **Culture Shock:** This is a situation whereby an individual sees something differently from his/her own perspective because of contradictions. It refers to difficulty to adjust to a new and different culture.
- e. **Sub-culture:** Sub-culture simply refers to group culture. It emerges whenever people occupying certain statuses in a society have shared experiences quite different from those of others in the society. A good example is the “Yan Kalare” thugs in Gombe.
- f. **Culture lag:** This is a concept that explains how various elements of culture change at a different pace and with what consequences. Usually the elements of culture related to technology change faster than non-material elements as a result of new invention. But society is considered to be a system in equilibrium with interrelated parts. Therefore, when some parts of society change more rapidly than others, such changes cause disruption in the social system. It takes time for all related parts of society to change and adapt to the new situation. This delay, is known as cultural lag, affects every society.

The importance of culture

- a. Understanding different cultures will make us understand why people behave the way they do, and be able to tolerate each other and by extension foster unity and peace in the society.
- b. Understanding culture helps in making us understand ourselves and the world around us.
- c. Culture is a complex strategy for meeting human needs. In this regard, its understanding entails understanding how different people satisfy their needs.
- d. Understanding culture enables human species identify means, mechanism and process of general and particular progress of human societies.

SOCIALIZATION

Every society is faced with the task of making the young children members of that society. The process of doing this is called socialization. Socialization is the process by which persons acquire the knowledge, skills and disposition that makes them more or less integrated members of their society. It is through the process of socialization that members learn certain habits, traditions, knowledge, skills, norms, and values which the society considers important. To Giddens (2005), socialization “is the process whereby the helpless infant gradually becomes a self-aware, knowledgeable person, skilled in ways of the culture into which she or he is born”.

Socialization continues through a person's life. It entails both the transmissions of the cultural heritage and the development of personality. Zanden (1977), pointed out that in the absence of socialization, society could not perpetuate itself beyond a single generation.

Types of Socialization



- a. Primary Socialization. This occurs in infancy and childhood and is the most intense period of cultural learning. It is the time when children learn language and basic behavioural patterns which form the foundation for later learning. The family is the main agent of socialization during this phase.
- b. Secondary Socialization. This takes place later in childhood and into maturity. In this phase, other agents of socialization take over some of the responsibility from the family. School, peer groups, organizations, the media and eventually the workplace become socializing forces for individuals. Social interactions in these contexts help people learn the values, norms and belief which make up the patterns of their culture.

Agents of Socialization

The process of socializing the young involves many segments of the society. Each role has distinct roles to play even though the ultimate goal is to make the young full members of the society. The socialization agents are;

- a. Peer Group: This is an important agent of socialization. The age grade or the peer group comprises of persons roughly the same age though the peer group is not an established institution like the school or the family, it has its own customs and organization. The peer group can be defined as a group composed of members of roughly equal age sharing equal status as well as pursuing some interests in common for example, if you are a university student, your course mates are your peers.
- b. The School: Schools are charged with formal task of passing on many of a culture's symbols, beliefs, values and norms. It is the school that the child extends the range of his human contacts and prepares himself to deal with a world infinitely more complex than his own family. Schools sometimes reinforce or extend the socialization received in the family, children begin learning language in the family, for example and the schools carry language instruction even further.
- c. The Church and the Mosque: The church and the mosque are socio-religious institutions in the society that help individuals satisfy the spiritual dimension of their needs. They are interested in the moral aspects of personality development of not only the children but the adults too. These religious institutions affect and influence the economic, political orientations, beliefs, values, intellectual and social growth of their members through their practices, preaching and teachings.
- d. The Mass Media: The media of mass communication include books, magazines, newspapers, posters in public places, advertising billboards, films, television, radio, internet etc. Unlike the school, the mass media is not a formal socializing institution but could be used in most cases by educators as a powerful instrument of socialization. Mass media often transmit messages of all sorts, direct information, entertainment, propaganda, persuasion etc. These messages affect people's orientations, values and experiences in no small measure this is not only socializing the child but also persist in the socialization of the adults.

Importance of Socialization

- a. Providing the foundation for the individual's effective participation in the society
- b. It inculcates basic discipline in the individual such as respect for elders, eating habit, etc.
- c. It instills aspiration in societal members
- d. It provides individuals with identities largely through the aspiration it encourages or discourages



- e. It provides for the stability, persistence and continuity of society by communicating the contents of the culture from one generation to the other

TRADITIONAL/CULTURAL FESTIVALS IN NIGERIA

Traditional festivals are periodic celebrations marking significant events in the life of a people or community. They are used to transmit ideas, aspirations and the philosophy of a people from one generation to another. In this regard, they are re-enactment of historical, religious and traditional events, which serve as factors of contact and interaction, cohesion and mobilization in these societies. The significance of these festivals in the past and even at present is that they serve as rallying points of groups. Every ethnic group in Nigeria has some form of festivals. Festivals are sometimes classified based on their purpose. Below are examples of these classifications:

1. **Fertility festival:** This is often performed by consulting the gods and ancestors in a quest for fertility and good health.
2. **Farming festival:** This festival is performed to seek for adequate and moderate rainfall, adequate food and to pray against general crop failure. During this festival, the first harvests are offered to the gods and ancestors. An example is New Yam Festival.
3. **Religious festival:** This involves worshipping of spirits of the dead or ancestors and goddess. During this festival, it is believed that the ancestors visit the living and in this process offer blessings and revelations. Examples include *ala* or *ani*, which involves worshipping of the earth goddess among the Igbo; and Osun festival, which involves worshipping of the river goddess. Worshipping of *ogun* (god of iron) by blacksmiths, drivers, etc is also an example of religious festival.
4. **Title taking and initiation festival:** This is performed to celebrate individual achievements and promotion from one age group to another. It also involves initiation into cult groups. Titles conferred here are either awarded or purchased.
5. **Funerals:** This is performed to celebrate the passing away (death) of elders of good repute. In this process, their souls are converted from wandering spirits to benevolent ancestors. It is believed that failure to observe this ceremony may cause the dead to come back and harm the living, in which case a second burial would be required.
6. **Modern festivals:** These are festivals that are not of Nigerian or African origin. They are either associated with Islam and Christianity or with government activities. Examples include Christmas, Easter, New Year, May Day, Independence, Maulud, Salah or Eid-el fitr and Eid-el kabir.

Case Studies

There are thousands of festivals observed by numerous ethnic groups in Nigeria. Some of these include the Durba in the north, Osun Oshogbo festival, new yam festival in the east, Argungu fishing festival, Shadi among the Fulani, Abuja Carnival, just to mention a few. Most of these ethnic groups are identified with traditional and ancient festivals that were observed for specific purposes such as religion,



initiation and economic activities. While many of these are still observed in the contemporary period, others have undergone some transformations. Meanwhile, others are observed as carnivals, involving music, dancing, procession, beauty pageant, prize giving, etc. Few of these shall be discussed below.

- a. **Osun festival:** this is the annual veneration festival organized by the Yoruba in honour of *Osun*, the wife of *Sango*, the god of thunder: its physical manifestation is the Osun River, which flows from the hills north of Ilesha and through the Yoruba country into the Lagos lagoon. The water of the Osun River is believed to make barren women fertile. The Osun annual festival takes place at the sanctuary of the goddess in Oshogbo in the month of August.
- b. **Lebokun festival (Yakun):** This is a sacred festival celebrated annually in Upep, northeast of Calabar. It is a yam festival in which the Yakun people thank the gods of the land for rich harvest. The festival, which takes the form of the ancestral worship in shrines, the offering of sacrifices, the performance of traditional dances and the shooting of a sacred tree Calabar.
- c. **Ofala festival:** This is a festival that accompanies the successful conclusion of a military campaign by the Igbo. In the past, it was intended to acknowledge very brave Igbo men who excelled at the battle ground and who, through such exploits had been able to guarantee the victory of communities over their enemies. During this festival, the community publicly demonstrates their loyalty and solidarity for the *Obi* and assures him of their unreserved support.
- d. **Sharo (flogging) festival:** The *Sharo* or *Shadi* festival is one of the significant festivals celebrated by the Fulani of northern Nigeria. It is usually celebrated twice yearly during the dry season and *Sallah* festival. The *Sharo* provides a regular platform for preserving the Fulani character of hardness, toughness, independence, self-reliance and rectitude in the face of extreme difficulties and also ensures that secrets, no matter the pressure, remain secret. This test of Fulani will ensure a high moral standard and fierce pride and independence. It is a celebration that is respected and honoured by both the nomadic and town Fulani.
- e. **Awon (mass wedding) festival:** This is a popular Yoruba festival celebrated to acknowledge the presence of *Awon* goddess. One remarkable feature of the celebration is the mass marrying of marriageable girls and boys. The *Awon* goddess is also believed to bless people with children during the celebration of this festival, which is usually in the month of October.
- f. **Igue festival:** Igue is an old festival among the Benin people. It was during the Igue festival in 1897 that British soldiers invaded Benin, banished their king (*Oba*) to Calabar and killed thousands of people and looted a large number of artefacts, some of which have been returned. This festival marks the end of the Edo year and ushers in a new one with renewed hope for peace and prosperity. The *Igue* is connected to several other festivals and religious rituals. Celebrated during the month of September, it serves to unite the Edo people. An important feature of this festival is that it is usually held at night, the only time when the *Oba's* wife is seen by the people as well as the time during which the *Obah* wears full traditional regalia and dances with the royal *Eben* in the presence of his subjects. During the festival wearing of red cap is prohibited except for members of the armed forces. The *Igue* festival is followed by fasting and prayer (*ague*) for peace and prosperity.



- g. Uhola Festival (Dakarkari Fakawa and Dukkawa):** The Dakarkari of Zum Local Government of Sokoto State are said to have evolved this festival from the people they met and interacted with during their migrations. The festival involves appeasement of the gods by pouring libations at their shrine. The gods are asked to provide rains for the farming season and peace in the community.
- h. Idu Festival (Nembe):** This is feast of the creator who the people collectively respect. For the Nembe people therefore, the creator deserves to be respected and his blessings to the people acknowledged in the celebration of all the community members. In this regard, the *Idu* festival is one in which the whole community or towns, its gods, spirits and ancestors and even the gods of neighbouring towns are involved.
- i. The Eje Alekwu Festival:** This is the Idoma ancestral veneration festival celebrated in the months of March and April. It is essentially a period when the Idoma thank the ancestors for the blessings of previous years and prospects for the years in view. Essentially a time for relaxation and merriment, the *Eje Alekwu* festival is a veritable institution for the mobilization of the Idoma. During the festival, the *Alekwu* masquerades come out in large numbers to the rhythm of local drums before retiring to their abode in the world beyond.
- j. The Argungu Fishing Festival:** This festival dates back to the 18th century and has its origin in the traditional fishing festival called *Su*. The festival, which attracts people from within and outside Nigeria takes place along the River Rima. During the festival, the best fisherman with the heaviest catch is awarded a prize. Fishing during the festival is undertaken manually in the age-long traditional ways in order to display the indigenous aquaculture.

The above cases are just few out of hundreds of traditional or cultural festivals in Nigeria. They show the diversity and richness of the cultures of the peoples of Nigeria. These cultures also tell a lot about the history of the people, their evolution over time and the nature and character of the societies they created and nurtured. As a multi-cultural polity, it is therefore imperative to harness this cultural diversity with a view to attaining national integration and development.

SOCIAL VICES

Social vices are deviant behaviours such as illicit sex, drug addiction, evil or immoral behaviour such as murder, examination malpractice, thuggery and such other criminal tendencies. Since the return of Nigeria to democratic rule in 1999, the country has been facing national security challenges across the six geo-political zones. Incidences of bomb blasts, oil pipeline vandalism, kidnappings, armed robbery and political assassinations are added dimensions to the security challenges, which are stretching the nation to its limits, sometimes constituting a great threat to the very fabric of its existence. Social vices are fast becoming national and global trends. Social vices cut across ethnic nationalities, races and even religious cleavages. Some of the social vices include but not limited to examination malpractice, indecent dressing and prostitution, political thuggery, cultism, drug addiction, targeted assassinations, armed robbery, pipeline vandalism, vandalism of electricity installations and cyber crimes. These vices are at variance to social norms and values which include beliefs, attitudes, honesty, hard work, customs and traditions, ideals, skills



and taboos which a society cherishes and passes on from one generation to another via formal and non formal education.

RE-ORIENTATION STRATEGIES

National Orientation Agency (NOA)

On 23rd August, 1993, an Act was passed to establish the National Orientation Agency to, among other things, re-orientate and encourage Nigerians to take part actively and freely in discussions and decisions affecting their general and collective welfare.

Composition

Apart from appointees of the President, the enabling Law provides for one representative from each of the following bodies and Ministries (i) the National Council of Women Societies (ii) the Nigeria Labour Congress (iii) the Nigerian Employers Consultative Association (iv) the Nigerian Association of Chambers of Commerce, Industries, Mines and Agriculture (v) the Nigerian Universities (vi) the Christian Association of Nigeria (vii) the Supreme Council for Islamic Affairs (viii) the Nigerian Bar Association (ix) the Federal Ministry of Information and National Orientation (x) the Federal Ministry of Education (xi) the Broadcasting Organisation of Nigeria (xii) the Nigerian Union of Journalists (xiii) the Nigerian Institute for Cultural Orientation

Functions

The functions of the Agency include the following:

- (a) to enlighten the general public on Federal Government policies, programmes and activities
- (b) to mobilise favourable public opinion and support for Federal Government policies, programmes and activities
- (c) to collect, collate, analyse and provide a source of feedback from the public to the Federal Government on its policies, programmes and activities
- (d) to establish social institutions and framework for deliberate exposure of Nigerians to democratic norms and values for virtue, peaceful, united, progressive and disciplined society
- (e) to energise the conscience of all categories of Nigerians to their rights and privileges, responsibilities and obligations as citizens of Nigeria
- (f) propagate and promote the spirit of dignity of labour, honesty and commitment of qualitative production, promotion and consumption of home-produced commodities and services
- (g) re-orientate Nigerians to shed their general attitudes to wastage, variety and pretences of affluence in their lifestyles



(h) orientate the populace about power, its use and the proper role of the Federal Government in serving the collective interest of Nigerians

(i) to propagate the need to eschew all vices in public life including corruption, dishonesty, electoral and census malpractice, ethnic, parochial and religious bigotry; propagate the virtue of hard work, honesty, loyalty, self-reliance, commitment to and the promotion of national integration

(k) to mobilise Nigerians for positive patriotic participation in and identification with national affairs and issues

(l) to sensitise, induct and equip all Nigerians to fight against all forms of internal and external domination of resources by a few individuals or groups

Mass Mobilization for Self Reliance, Social Justice, and Economic Recovery (MAMSER)

MAMSER was an exercise in political orientation in Nigeria undertaken by former president Ibrahim Babangida as one of the recommendations of the political bureau headed by Samuel Cookey. The task of the bureau was to consult with thousands of Nigerians and recommend to the Armed Forces Ruling Council, a respectable and methodical transition programme. The ruling council also wanted a national orientation to enunciate the abstract ideas in its economic policy and promote value orientation towards mobilizing the populace for MAMSER was inaugurated on July 25th, 1987.

There were other programmes initiated by different governments since independence, which have in one way or the other recognized the need to mobilize the people as a way of changing the prevalent negative value system. These programmes have included the following: the Code of Conduct Bureau of the Murtala/Obasanjo military regime; The National Ethical Re-orientation Committee of the Shagari regime; The War Against Indiscipline of the Buhari regime; the Centre for Democratic Studies of the Babangida regime and the Independent Corrupt Practices Commission (ICPC) and the Economic and Financial Crimes Commission (EFCC) of the Obasanjo regime.